

AISH vs ADAP — Language Cheat Sheet

One verb decides it. AISH = a disability that permanently PREVENTS work. ADAP = one that significantly IMPEDES but does not prevent work.

AISH — keeps the file here (permanently PREVENTS work)	ADAP — language routes you here (IMPEDES, not prevents)
Prevents · precludes · makes work impossible	Impedes · restricts · limits · makes work harder
Cannot / unable to sustain employment	Struggles with / manages with effort
Permanent — not expected to improve with treatment	Manageable · stable on treatment · improving · responding well
Options tried and exhausted	Currently in treatment / may benefit from more
Unpredictable incapacity — cannot commit to any schedule	Has good days and bad days
Cannot reliably start, organize, or finish tasks unaided	Needs some help / does better with support
No accommodation makes work reliable or sustained	With accommodation / the right workplace, could work
The disability itself is the main factor barring work	If retrained / with experience, employment is realistic

How placement works: an adjudicator can grant ADAP alone; AISH must be referred up to a medical panel. Hedged or ambiguous wording stays at the adjudicator’s desk, which is ADAP. An unclear file defaults DOWN, never up.

YOUR PART (DS2444A) — the fields where wording matters		THE MEDICAL REPORT (DS2444B) — the fields that decide it	
Q13 Willing to work?	Answer truthfully, usually YES. Willingness is not the test, ability to sustain work is. Put the “can’t” in Q15.	Q7 Medical history	Tie each condition to a duration and functional restriction; close on permanence and “limits earning a livelihood on a reliable, sustained basis.”
Q15 How disability affects work (“optional”)	The most important box. Write what you CANNOT reliably do, how you are UNPREDICTABLE, and what trying to work has COST you.	Q40 / Q68 Cumulative impairment	Rate to the true picture (0–3); do not under-rate. Note variability (“3 on flare days, 1 between”). Do not average it away.
Q16 Currently employed?	If you do a little, say Yes and describe the cost. “A little, at great cost” is evidence of how hard work is, not proof you are fine.	Q69–74 Remedial therapy	The permanence gate. State treatments tried or exhausted and why more will not restore work capacity. Inaccessible therapy = not available.
Q21 Reason for leaving	If health ended the job, check “Medical condition.” Do not soften to “quit,” that reads as a choice, not the disability.	Q75 Prognosis	Choose PERMANENT where supported (or Episodic with quantified unpredictability). Avoid “Undetermined,” it defaults to ADAP.
		Q76 Additional comments	Synthesis: cumulative, permanent, not correctable by accommodation, substantially limits ability to earn a livelihood.

Three phrases that carry a file to AISH: “not correctable by workplace accommodation” · “on a reliable, sustained basis” · “not expected to improve with treatment / options exhausted.”

The guardrail: complete every field truthfully. Use AISH’s vocabulary where AISH is the truth; if work is truly possible, ADAP is the right, and still strong, program. Overstating can lose the case you truly have.

General information, not legal or medical advice. — The Alberta Disability System Breakdown, July 2026.